

"Rajamma, my aunt, often told me stories from the Puranas. That was the best education I ever received."

# THE ENERGISER

His belief in the necessity of building indigenous capability in nuclear technology is directly responsible for the position of strength India finds itself in today

■ By P. K. Iyengar

**R**aja Ramanna completed his early education in India, and took his Ph.D. in nuclear physics from King's College, London, as a Tata scholar. He joined Homi Bhabha at the Tata Institute of Research in 1949 and was asked to initiate research in nuclear physics in the country. I joined him there in 1952 and worked with him for over five decades, succeeding him to the various posts he held in the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE).

He was able to combine the Indian tradition of original thinking with the more modern western way of thought, which creates science and ends up in technology. He also realised that generating

properly-trained manpower was essential to rapid growth in science and technology. Which is why, in 1957, he established a training school at the Atomic Energy Establishment, Trombay, inducting every year 200 of the best graduates in science and engineering and giving them high quality training. This school has produced many who are now leaders in DAE.

One of the milestones in his (and

**Nuclear scientist 1925-2004**

the nation's) life was the first nuclear test in 1974 that shook the world. Ramanna put together a fine bunch of scientists who could deliver when demanded by Indira Gandhi. The organisation of these efforts was based on the old Indian concept of mutual trust. Morarji Desai shifted him to the department of defence as scientific adviser to the defence minister, in

which capacity he reformed the Defence Research and Development Organisation and infused fresh life into it. But when Gandhi met him in Kashmir while she was out of office, she remarked: "Oh, your place is in atomic energy. Why did they shift you?" She brought him back in 1982. Not to say that his relations with the establishment were always smooth. He had a running battle with the PMO when Rajiv Gandhi was prime minister, on his disagreement to importing reactors from the Soviet Union. He had, however, very cordial relations with the Soviet Union which helped him get a nuclear submarine on lease.

*The author is former chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission*



**Q: What was his abiding passion, other than science?**

A: Music

**Q: Which eminent scientist did he admire?**

A: Homi Bhabha

**Q: Whose offer did he once decline?**

A: Saddam Hussein's in 1978 to build a nuclear bomb for Iraq